

European mole

Talpa europaea

- ↔ 4–7 in (12–18 cm)
- 📍 Europe to N. Asia
- ⊗ Common

long, cylindrical body



Specialized for living underground, this virtually blind mole uses its powerful, spadelike feet to dig a network of tunnels radiating from a central chamber. It pushes the excavated soil up to the surface, forming a series of distinctive molehills. Its short, dense black fur can lie in either direction, allowing the mole to move forward or backward through the soil. It feeds on worms, insect grubs, and other animals that fall into the tunnels, detecting them by touch, smell, and sound. The female gives birth to three or four young.

Pangolins

Order Pholidota

Ground pangolin

Manis temminckii

- ↔ 20–24 in (50–61 cm)
- 📍 E. to Southern Africa
- ⊗ Vulnerable

Pangolins are insect-eating mammals with a unique body armor of large, overlapping scales made of keratin. If threatened, they can roll up into an armored ball. This species eats ants and termites, using its large claws to rip open their nests. It laps them up with a sticky tongue about 16 in (40 cm) long—half the length of its body.



Other species

- Common pangolin
Manis tricuspis » p215

Carnivores

Order Carnivora

Fennec fox

Vulpes zerda

- ↔ 10–16 in (25–41 cm)
- 📍 N. Africa
- ⊗ Common

Native to the arid lands of the Sahara, the fennec is the smallest of all foxes. It is remarkable for its big, sensitive ears, which it uses to

detect prey such as insects and mice in the desert night; they may also help it to dissipate heat. It has a broad diet, eating fruit and seeds as well as small animals. It is adapted to minimize water loss, which means that it rarely needs to drink.

huge, batlike ears to radiate body heat



long, thick hairs protect from cold

Rüppels fox

Vulpes rueppellii

- ↔ 25 in (64 cm)
- 📍 N. and E. South America
- ⊗ Common

Also called the sand fox, Rüppels fox is similar to the red fox but slighter in build. It has soft, dense, sandy or silver-gray fur to match its arid habitat, black patches on the sides of the muzzle, and a white tail tip. In some regions, this species forms monogamous pairs, but in others, it gathers in groups of up to 15. It eats a variety of food from grass to insects, reptiles, and mammals.

Bush dog

Speothos venaticus

- ↔ 23–30 in (58–76 cm)
- 📍 N. and C. South America
- ⊗ Near threatened

This long-bodied, short-snouted, short-legged wild dog lives in packs of up to 12 in the tropical forests of the Amazon. This powerful and persistent hunter hunts by day, using group tactics that enable it to bring down large animals such as deer and capybaras. Each pack has a mated pair and offspring of various ages; only the dominant pair breeds, but other members of the pack help to defend and feed the youngest pups.

Crab-eating fox

Cerdocyon thous

- ↔ 25 in (64 cm)
- 📍 N. and E. South America
- ⊗ Common

Widespread on the grasslands and open woodlands of tropical South America, this medium-sized fox is an opportunist hunter that often preys on crabs, both in freshwater habitats and on the coast. It also takes various other prey, ranging from insect grubs to small mammals and fish as well as eggs and fruit. It is usually grayish brown above and white below.

